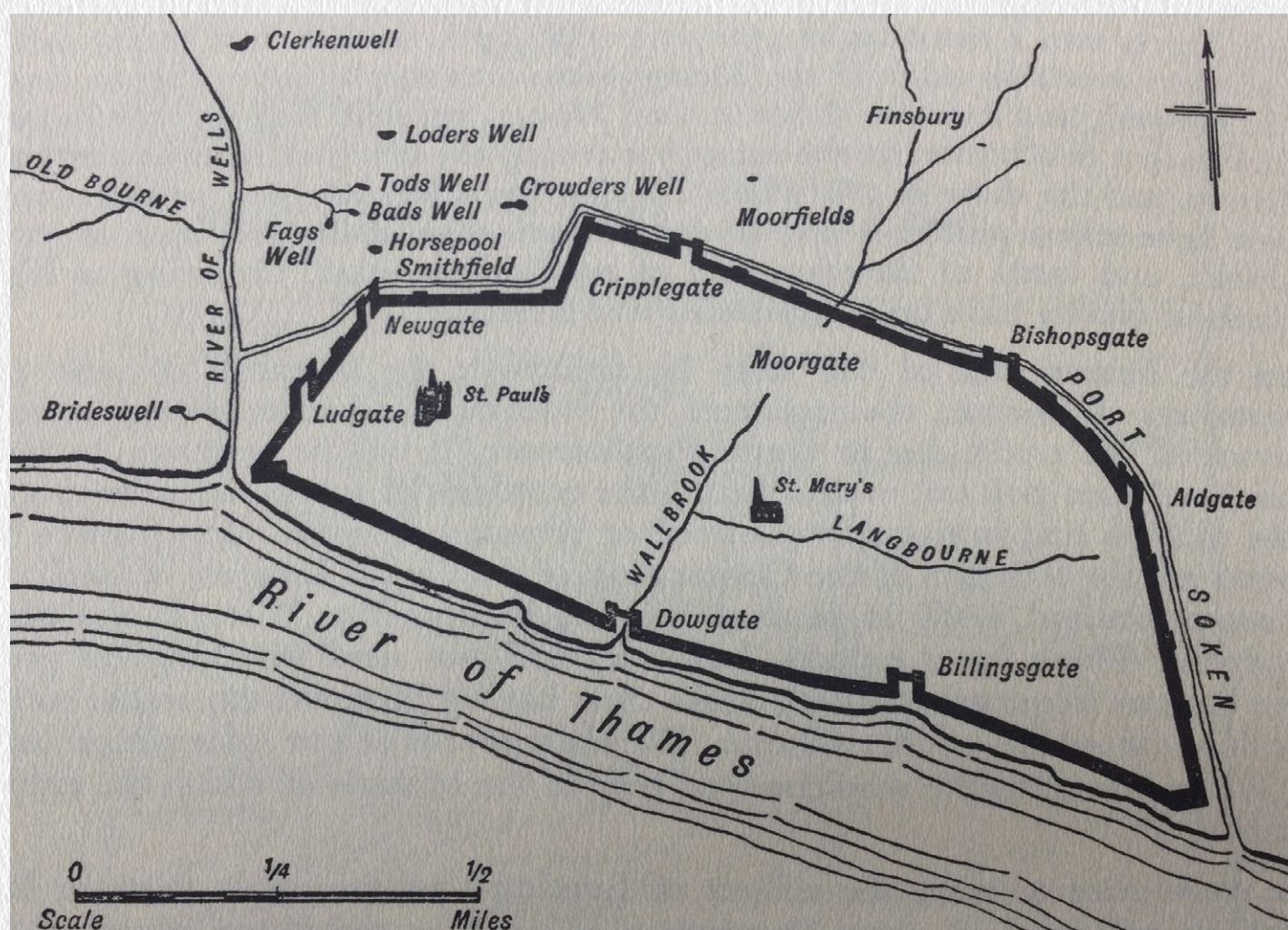


The Great Conduit

No. 165

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

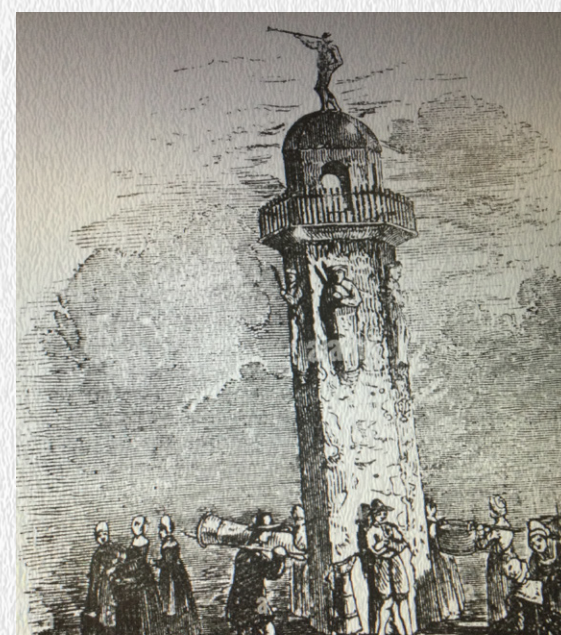
April 2026



Map of Saxon London, Circa 1000 AD



The conduit passing over the River Fleet



The Conduit of River Fleet

In early medieval times, Londoners relied on water from the River Fleet (known earlier as the River of Wells) or the River Wallbrook with its tributary, the Langbourne, or from the many wells on the northern fringes of the city.

These sources proved inadequate for a growing population. William Fitzstephen wrote in the late 1100s of the “sweet, wholesome and clear springs, rippling bright over the pebbles”. In 1237, the City of London acquired the source of the River Tyburn, and built a small reservoir. There is a plaque at the corner of Marylebone Lane and Wigmore Street which records the sources of the River Tyburn. Work on the conduit started in 1245.

The Conduit in Fleet Street was a small tower-like structure, apparently in the middle of the road at the junction with Shoe Lane. Stow reports that it consisted of a stone tower, decorated with an image of St. Christopher on top and angels lower down round about it and with sweet-sounding bells which chimed every hour through an engine placed in the tower. The Conduit started from a source near Paddington, and came past Charing Cross and the Strand to Fleet Street, and went on to Cheapside.

A 1478 record describes “a wax chandler in Fleet Street had by craft pierced a pipe of the Conduit within the ground and so conveyed the water into his cellar.”

The Conduit not only supplied water to the Fleet Street area, but it also formed a feature in many of the pageants held in the City from medieval times up to the Great Fire. When Anne Boleyn processed from the Tower to her coronation at Westminster, the Conduit was reported to be flowing with wine rather than water, and it was decorated and surmounted with angels. A pageant was held at the Conduit when Philip II of Spain came to wed Queen Mary, and another pageant was held there for Queen Elizabeth’s coronation in 1558. The Conduit was also a favoured place for the posting of proclamations.

The conduit gave frequent problems for neighbouring houses and businesses, which on several occasions petitioned the Lord Mayor to repair the Conduit “to obviate the damage done by the overflowing of the Conduit frequently through the breaking of the pipes there, rotted and damaged their houses and cellars and their party walls thereof, and their goods and wares.”